Synthetic User Research Report

Generated 21 Sep 2026, 17:46

Research Context

Product: Placement Prep AI: a Campus-to-Corporate Readiness Platform that helps final-year college students prepare for company-specific placement interviews. It uses synthetic interviewer personas (e.g. 'Strict Infosys HR', 'Friendly TCS Tech Lead') to simulate real HR, technical and coding rounds, gives resume feedback via synthetic recruiter personas, and detects weak areas in communication, technical depth and confidence.
Target audience: Final-year engineering/college students preparing for campus placements, including students at tier-2/tier-3 colleges with little access to real mock interviews; also Training & Placement (T&P) cell officers who want to track batch-wide readiness; also companies wanting a standardized screening simulation.
Research goal: Decide which features to prioritize for the MVP launch this placement season: mock interview personas, coding round simulation, resume feedback, or weak-area analytics dashboards for T&P cells.
Personas simulated: 5
Survey questions: 6

Executive Summary

Across 5 personas spanning students, a T&P officer, and a campus recruiter, the dominant signal is clear: preparation is too generic, communication/HR rounds are the universal confidence gap, and mock interview personas are the single most-prioritized MVP feature (3 of 5 votes in q6). Weak-area analytics dashboards are a strong second choice, especially for T&P operators. Resume feedback serves as a critical 'gate' feature for non-CSE and anxious students but is viewed as secondary by most others. Coding round simulation is the clear laggard — students already self-practice and recruiters see it as narrower than full-round simulation. The MVP should launch with mock interview personas as the core, with a lightweight analytics dashboard as a complementary feature, and resume feedback as a fast-follow.
Overall sentiment: MIXED

Personas Surveyed

Name	Occupation	Tech-savvy	Key pain point
Arjun	Final-year B.Tech CSE student, Tier-3 college (pr	medium	T&P cell conducts interviews only once-per-semester, 30 stud
Meera Sharma	Training & Placement (T&P) Cell Officer at a Tier-2 Engineering College	medium	time-consuming manual tracking of student progress
Rohan Mehta	Final-year B.Tech Computer Science student,	high	Overwhelmed by the sheer volume and variety of intervie
Priya Nair	Technical Recruiter / Campus Hiring Lead at a mid-size IT services company (500-1000 employees)	medium	Wasting 60-70% of their time on shortlisted candidates who can
Sneha Iyer	Final-year B.Tech Mechanical Engineering student at a Tier-2 government-aided college	low	Finds AI-based platforms and new digital tools intimidating

Key Themes

Universal Communication/HR Round Deficit (prevalence: high)

Communication and HR round weakness is the #1 confidence gap across all student personas (p1, p3, p5) and is observed by the recruiter (p4). Students freeze, use verbal fillers, and interpret silence as rejection. p4 notes candidates 'can recite definitions but cannot explain design choices.' This is the most universally shared pain point.
Supported by: p1, p3, p5, p4

Generic Preparation vs. Company-Specific Needs (prevalence: high)
All 5 personas cite that current preparation is too generic and not company-specific. p1's T&P mocks are 'generic questions, company-specific kuch nahi.' p2 manually tracks hundreds of students because preparation isn't tailored. p3 can't find 'a single consolidated resource that covers all of them with company-specific depth.' p5 doesn't know 'what a particular company actually asks.' This creates the core value proposition for company-specific interviewer personas.
Supported by: p1, p2, p3, p4, p5

Mock Interview Personas as the Top MVP Priority (prevalence: high)
Mock interview personas received the most q6 votes (p1, p3, p4). Students value them because they already self-practice coding (p1, p3) and need realistic practice across HR, technical, and behavioral rounds in one feature. p2 values them for scalable weekly mocks. p4 values them because they 'give the best signal on communication, project ownership, technical depth, and confidence in one exercise.'
Supported by: p1, p3, p4, p2

Analytics Dashboards: High Value but Design-Sensitive (prevalence: medium)
Analytics dashboards are highly valued by the T&P officer (p2, 5/5) and the methodical student (p3, 5/5). p2 sees them as essential for batch-level intervention and resource allocation. p3 wants 'granular, competency-based diagnostic reports.' However, p1 warns the dashboard must be simple — 'agar bohot fancy ya complex lage toh main avoid karunga.' This creates a design tension between depth and accessibility.
Supported by: p2, p3, p1

Resume Feedback: Important Gate, Quality-Conditional (prevalence: medium)
Resume feedback is seen as important but conditional. p2 rates it 5/5 as a 'first screening layer.' p5 (non-CSE, anxious) uniquely prioritizes it as the 'first barrier' — if she doesn't get shortlisted, mock interviews won't happen. But p3 and p4 both warn against generic/template-based feedback: p3 says 'if it's just another template-based tool, I'd rate it a 2,' and p4 notes AI suggestions can 'make resumes look more polished without making candidates more employable.'
Supported by: p2, p5, p3, p4

Coding Simulation: Lowest Priority as Standalone Feature (prevalence: high)
Coding round simulation received zero q6 votes. p1 already practices on CodeChef/LeetCode (easy/medium). p3 practices coding thoroughly alone. p4 values it but calls it 'narrower' than full-round simulation. The product team should treat coding simulation as a feature within mock personas, not a standalone MVP pillar.
Supported by: p1, p3, p4

Notable Quotes

- p1: 'Main khud ko record karta hoon phone pe 5-6 baar re-record karta hoon taaki acceptably lage' — self-recording as a coping mechanism for HR anxiety
- p2: 'Manual spreadsheet tracking cannot provide this level of visibility' — T&P officer explicitly requesting data-driven intervention tools

- p3: 'That gap between my technical capability and my ability to present it under pressure is where I feel least confident' — the impostor syndrome pattern
- p4: 'They can recite definitions but cannot explain design choices, trade-offs, bugs, or what they would improve' — recruiter's sharpest critique of candidate readiness
- p5: 'If I do not get shortlisted, mock interviews will not happen' — resume as the gatekeeper for non-CSE students
- p1: 'agar dashboard bohot fancy ya complex lage toh main avoid karunga' — explicit warning against over-engineering analytics

Weak Areas / Risks

- Coding simulation as a standalone feature has zero demand signal — building it as a separate MVP pillar would misallocate resources.
- Analytics dashboard complexity risk: p1 explicitly states he would avoid a 'fancy' dashboard. Over-engineering analytics could alienate the most anxious user segment.
- Resume feedback quality risk: p3 and p4 both caution that low-quality AI resume feedback can make resumes 'look more polished without making candidates more employable' — this could damage platform trust.
- Non-CSE adoption risk: p5's hesitation ('too many steps,' 'not for people like her') suggests the platform may struggle to attract non-CSE students without deliberate simplification and word-of-mouth seeding.
- AI skepticism from recruiters: p4 is 'skeptical of AI tools that claim to replace human judgment.' The platform must position itself as augmenting recruiter judgment, not replacing it.
- Tier-3 college anxiety and self-selection bias: p1 and p3 both assume 'elite' or 'expensive' tools aren't for them. If the platform's marketing or pricing feels premium, these students may self-exclude before trying.
- p5's mixed sentiment on personas (0.86 confidence, 'mixed') signals that even interested users need reassurance that the tool is 'supportive rather than complicated' — the persona simulation must feel safe, not intimidating.

Recommendations

- Launch MVP with mock interview personas as the core feature — company-specific HR, technical, and behavioral rounds (e.g., 'Strict Infosys HR', 'Friendly TCS Tech Lead'). This addresses the universal communication deficit and the generic-practice gap simultaneously.
- Build a lightweight, simple analytics dashboard as a complementary feature — not a standalone MVP pillar. p1's explicit warning ('agar fancy lage toh avoid karunga') means the dashboard must prioritize clarity over depth at launch. Start with 3 metrics: communication gap, technical depth, confidence trend.
- Treat coding round simulation as a module within mock interview personas, not a separate feature. Students already self-practice coding; what they lack is integrated practice with feedback across all round types.
- Design resume feedback as a fast-follow feature with strict quality controls. p3 and p4 both warn that generic AI resume feedback can backfire. The MVP should focus on company-specific keyword and achievement framing, not template polishing.
- Build a 'simple onboarding' path specifically for non-CSE and anxious students like p5. Her hesitation ('AI tools are not for people like her') means the first-run experience must be minimal, WhatsApp-integrated, or peer-reassured. Consider a 'senior recommended' onboarding flow.

- Include a 'Tier-3 college sensitivity' layer in persona design. p1 and p3 both express anxiety that AI tools may judge them harshly or feel 'elite.' Personas should use language and expectations calibrated to Tier-2/3 college contexts, not just Tier-1 corporate norms.